Decolonizing the Museum

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ARE540 Show and Tell

Positionality

- She/her, feminist
- Mother, married
- Cisgender, vaguely bisexual
- White, Western European
- Millennial
- Depressed, ADHD
- Leftist

Subjectivity

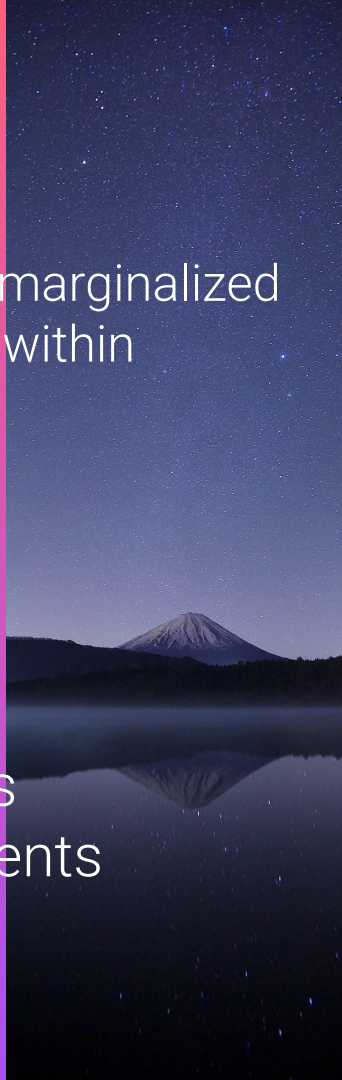
My subjectivity is informed largely by my perspective as a mother. I pursue my understanding looking through a social justice lens because of my liberal upbringing and desire to help, support, and learn from marginalized communities. I view research data from the perspective of someone in the midst of a motherhood experience as well as someone who puts a focus on behavioral health. My privilege as a white person further informs my perspective by understanding the need for decolonization strategies and the role myself and my culture has played in perpetuating colonial practices and ideas.

Research Focus

Utilizing developing technologies to increase access to museums for marginalized communities. Technologies that can be used to improve accessibility within museum institutions can be assistive or based in programming.

Examples

- 3D printing
- Telepresence robots
- Digital access
- Immersive experience
- Touchscreens
- Digital labels
- Sensory experiences
- Personal digital docents



What Decolonialism Is

- Dismantling colonial systems and hierarchies
- Returning land and objects
- Shifting perspectives toward equity
- Honest narratives
- Independence and reclamation
- Privileged responsibility

What Decolonialism Isn't

- White saviors
- White-centered
- A trend
- Metaphorical - requires *real* action
- Exploitative
- Improving systems

5 Steps to Decolonization

(Laenui 2000).

1. **Rediscovery and Recovery** *"This phase of rediscovering one's history and recovering one's culture, language, identity, and so on is fundamental to the movement for decolonization. It forms the basis for the steps to follow."* (p. 82).
2. **Mourning**
3. **Dreaming** *"It is during this phase that colonized people are able to explore their own cultures, experience their own aspirations for their future, and consider their own structures of government and social order to encompass and express their hopes."* (p. 84).
4. **Commitment** "...elitist solutions are quick substitutes for the decolonization process, and they deprive the people of a participatory role in the formation of their own social order" (p. 87).
5. **Action**

Examples of Decolonization

"Decolonization brings about the repatriation of Indigenous land and life; it is not a metaphor for other things we want to do to improve our societies and schools" (Tuck and Yang, 2012).

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- Political restructuring
- Centering marginalized voices
- Colonial renaming efforts
- Reevaluation of policy
- Repatriation
- Critical analysis - *Whose knowledge is considered default?*
- Restorative justice, unlearning harmful behaviors
- Community models - democratic decision making

Why Museums?

- Museums - historically considered place of inspiration.
- Original concepts of museum - ca. 3rd century BCE in Alexandria.
- Wunderkammen, “cabinet of curiosities”, 15-1600s - private, wealthy
- British Museum, 1753 - first public museum

Role of Museums

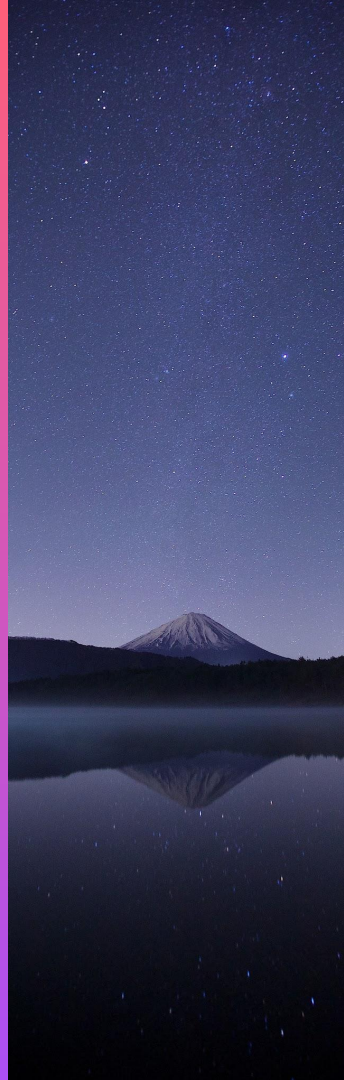
- Preservation
- Education
- Research
- Representation

Responsibility of Museums

- Non-neutral
- Truth telling
- Community engagement
- Cultural preservation and support
- Social responsibility

Decolonizing the Museum

- Changing programming to embrace previously ignored communities
- Working with communities
- Repatriation
- Guest community curators
- Rewriting exhibition materials and labels
- Transparent labeling and classification systems
- Re-examination of security policy and protocols



Objective

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The goal of decolonizing the museum is to reassemble the museum institution to reflect an honest, accurate, and equitable narrative and abolish the systems that led us here in the first place.

Decolonization Opportunities?

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- **Labels denoting African masks as "Artist Unknown"** - disregards the artist's culture as static or primitive
- **Indigenous objects featured as artifacts rather than art** - designates non-Western cultures as mysterious and exotic
- **Western narratives centered** - ignores non-Western voices
- **Indigenous cultures represented without context** - fetishizes and capitalizes on Indigenous symbols
- **Increased surveillance of museum goers** - rooted in racist ideology
- **Ignorance of labor in art** - disregarding enslaved labor

In Closing

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Decolonizing the museum isn't adding new voices, new policy, new ideas. It is about breaking down and reimagining a broken system to reflect honest, direct, and reparative action and narratives. This can be done if the current voices within the institution are willing to be accountable and transparent.

References

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- Laenui, P. (Burgess, H. F.) (2000). Processes of decolonization. *Reclaiming indigenous voice and vision*. Ed. Marie Battiste. Vancouver, BC: UBC Press, 2000. 150-160
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THANK YOU

Any questions?